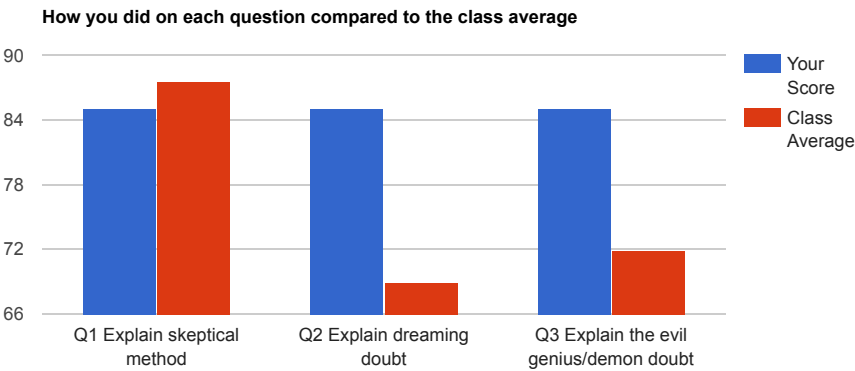


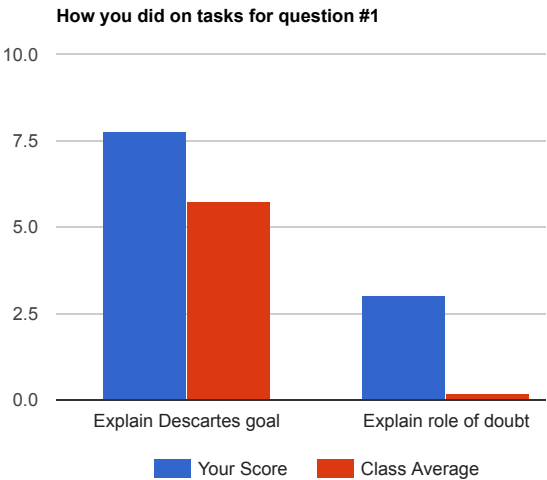
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Q1: Explain skeptical method

You did a good job recognizing that in order to say why Descartes has adopted the skeptical method of the Meditations, the reader needed to be told what Descartes is hoping to achieve. It was completely clear from your answer that he is trying to discover what kinds of beliefs can be the completely certain foundations upon which the rest of our knowledge can be built. From your explanation I think a reader would have been able to see that the idea is to find some beliefs which Descartes can't be wrong about. Then he can work backwards to explaining why and when, for example, scientific beliefs count as certain knowledge.

You need to explain the role doubt plays in Descartes method. He is using a principle like "If I can find grounds for doubting that a kind of belief is true, then no beliefs of that sort count as knowledge". So, for example, if we're talking about beliefs based on seeing things in the distance, I might believe that I see a plane. But then someone points out that birds are often confused with faraway planes. Now I can't say that I know that object in the distance is a plane until I can be sure that it is not a bird.

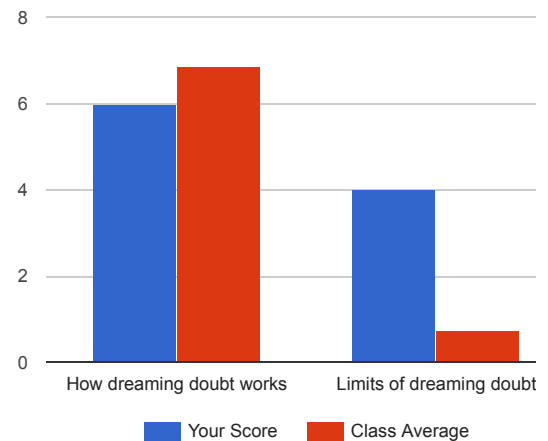


Q2: Explain dreaming doubt

You did a pretty good job explaining Descartes' argument that when you are dreaming, things just the way they do when you are awake. It would've been mostly clear to a reader that in a dream you can't tell that you are dreaming. So, if Descartes were dreaming right now, he would not know that he was dreaming. Yet all of his beliefs about what is around him would be false ---he thinks he is in front of the fire, but actually he is snuggled up in bed. Since many beliefs based on his senses would be false if he were dreaming, he has found a reason to doubt all such beliefs.

You correctly pointed out that Descartes notices that the possibility of being asleep and dreaming does not actually undermine all beliefs based on sense experience. In dreams, he has false beliefs about complex things. For example, his dream that he sees a centaur --a mythical creature that is half-horse and half-man-- involves his mind sneakily putting together two more simple things. From your answer I think a reader probably would've been able to see why, even in dreams the really simple things, like arithmetical and geometric truths are still the same. Even in dreams squares have four sides; the Pythagorean theorem still works. So the possibility of being asleep only shows that he can't trust his sense-based beliefs about complex things. Thus despite some weakness here, I think your answer did an okay job of explaining why Descartes has not yet found reason to doubt mathematical truths and other simple beliefs.

How you did on tasks for question #2



Q3: Explain the evil genius/demon doubt

You did a bit to explain how, after realizing the limits of the dreaming doubt, Descartes considers whether there is any way his beliefs about arithmetic could be wrong. However, I don't think a reader would've been able to see how Descartes concludes that an all powerful being could trick him into having false beliefs. For example, every time he went to put a pile of two rocks next to a pile of three rocks and count how many he has in total, the demon could sneak in and add a rock. He would then believe that $2+3 = 6$.

As was reasonably clear from your answer, this sort of reasoning seems to undermine any possible belief: If you ask yourself, "Can I really be sure that there's no chance some all powerful super smart demon is tricking me about this?" I think a reader probably would've been able to see that the answer seems like it will always be 'No'. Thus you cannot trust your beliefs. It was also pretty clear from your answer that Descartes realizes that there is one crucial exception: He cannot doubt that he exists. The demon could trick him about pretty much anything. But the demon would always be tricking someone, namely, him. So whenever he is thinking, he must exist to be the thing doing the thinking. Therefore, he cannot doubt that he exists. There were a few problems with your explanation of this. But I think a reader probably would've been able to understand why this is famously summed up: Cogito ergo sum (I think therefore I am).

How you did on tasks for question #3

